

Antinatalism

Antinatalism or **anti-natalism** is the [philosophical value judgment](#) that [procreation](#) is [unethical](#) or unjustifiable. Antinatalists thus argue that humans should abstain from making children.^{[1][2][3][4][5]} Some antinatalists consider coming into [existence](#) to always be a serious harm. Their views are not necessarily limited only to humans but may encompass all [sentient](#) creatures, arguing that coming into existence is a serious harm for sentient beings in general.^{[6]: 2–3, 163 [7][8][9][10]}

There are various reasons why antinatalists believe human reproduction is problematic. The most common arguments for antinatalism include that life entails inevitable suffering, death is inevitable, and humans are born without their consent (that is to say, they cannot choose whether or not they come into existence). Additionally, although some people may turn out to be happy, this is not guaranteed, so to procreate is to gamble with another person's suffering. There is also an [axiological](#) asymmetry between good and bad things in life, such that coming into existence is always a harm, which is known as [Benatar's asymmetry argument](#).

Antinatalism as a philosophical concept is to be distinguished from antinatalist policies employed by some countries (governmental [population control](#) measures). In antinatalist population policy, it is not always implied that coming into existence is a universal problem and is an ever-present harm to the one whose existence was started.^{[11][5]}

There exists a taxonomy that divides the so-called "antiprocreative" (at times called antinatalist) thought into four major branches: [childfreeness](#), the [Voluntary Human Extinction Movement](#) (VHEMT), [efilism](#) (an ideology that advocates for extreme promortalism and forced extinction), and antinatalism itself. Only the latter one is philosophical antinatalism *per se*, meeting the definition of philosophical antinatalism and having no other features on top of that, whereas the first three items can only be deemed antinatalistic in the sense that they oppose the alleged duty to procreate.^{[5][12]}

Etymology

The term *antinatalism* (in opposition to the term [natalism](#), *pronatalism* or *pro-natalism*) was used probably for the first time by [Théophile de Giraud](#) in his book *L'art de guillotiner les procréateurs: Manifeste anti-nataliste* (2006).^{[1]: 301} [Masahiro Morioka](#) defines antinatalism as "the thought that all human beings or all sentient beings should not be born."^{[12]: 2} In scholarly and literary writings, various ethical arguments have been put forth in defense of antinatalism, probably the most prominent of which is the asymmetry argument, put forward by [South African](#) philosopher [David Benatar](#). Robbert Zandbergen makes a distinction between so-called reactionary (or activist) antinatalism and its more philosophical, originary counterpart. While the former seeks to limit human reproduction locally and/or temporarily, the latter seeks to end it conclusively.^[9]

History

Early history

Antinatalist sentiments have existed for thousands of years. Some of the earliest surviving formulations of the idea that it would be better not to have been born can be found in [ancient Greece](#).^{[13][14]} One example is from [Sophocles](#)'s *Oedipus at Colonus*, written shortly before Sophocles's death in 406 BC.^[15]

Not to be born is, beyond all estimation, best; but when a man has seen the light of day, this is next best by far, that with utmost speed he should go back from where he came. For when he has seen

youth go by, with its easy merry-making, what hard affliction is foreign to him, what suffering does he not know? Envy, factions, strife, battles, and murders. Last of all falls to his lot old age, blamed, weak, unsociable, friendless, wherein dwells every misery among miseries

The Arab philosopher [al-Ma'arri](#) expressed aninatalist sentiments throughout his life. In an [elegy](#) composed by him over the loss of a relative, he combines his grief with observations on the [ephemerality](#) of this life:

Soften your tread. Methinks the earth's surface is but bodies of the dead,
Walk slowly in the air, so you do not trample on the remains of God's servants.^[16]

Al-Ma'arri's self-composed [epitaph](#), on his tomb, states (in regard to life and being born): "This is my father's crime against me, which I myself committed against none."^[17]

From [Gustave Flaubert](#), *The Letters of Gustave Flaubert 1830–1857*, 1846:

The idea of bringing someone into the world fills me with horror. I would curse myself if I were a father. A son of mine! Oh no, no, no! May my entire flesh perish and may I transmit to no one the aggravations and the disgrace of existence

From [Arthur Schopenhauer](#)'s [Parerga and Paralipomena](#), 1851:^{[6]: 163 [18]}

One should try to imagine that the act of procreation were neither a need, nor accompanied by sexual pleasure, but instead a matter of pure, rational reflection; could the human race even continue to exist? Would not everyone, on the contrary, have so much compassion for the coming generation that he would rather spare it the burden of existence, or at least refuse to take it upon himself to cold-bloodedly impose it on them?^{[19]: 270}

Arguments

In religion

Buddhism

The teaching of the [Buddha](#), including the [Four Noble Truths](#) and the beginning of [Mahāvagga](#), is interpreted by [Hari Singh Gour](#) as follows:

Buddha states his propositions in the pedantic style of his age. He throws them into a form of sorites; but, as such, it is logically faulty and all he wishes to convey is this: Oblivious of the suffering to which life is subject, man begets children, and is thus the cause of old age and death. If he would only realize what suffering he would add to by his act, he would desist from the procreation of children; and so stop the operation of old age and death.^[20]

The issue of [Buddhist](#) antinatalism is also raised by Amy Paris Langenberg. She writes, among other things:

In the medieval Tantric traditions of India and Tibet documented by David Gray and Janet Gyatso, insertive but non-ejaculative sex is theorized as a fast path to liberating realizations, one deemed superior to celibacy for qualified practitioners (Gray 2007; Gyatso 1998). These developments also support the idea that the sex problematic in ancient, classical, and medieval Buddhism had at least as much to do with female fertility and the production of children as with the dangers of errant desire.^[21]

Buddhism was understood as antinatalist by [Jack Kerouac](#).^[22] [Masahiro Morioka](#) argues that ancient Buddhism was both antinatalist and anti-antinatalist:

According to ancient Buddhism, all births are births into the world of suffering; hence, coming into existence must be evaluated negatively. If we focus on this aspect, we can say that ancient Buddhism is antinatalist. However, we can also interpret ancient Buddhism as saying that being born into this human world is affirmed because there is a possibility of reaching nirvana here. Therefore, if we pay attention to this aspect, we cannot instantaneously say that it is antinatalist.^[23]

Christianity and Gnosticism

Church Father [John Chrysostom](#) states that spiritual perfection implies virginity:^[24]

Thus hath our Lord in His mercy mingled much gentleness with His precepts that it might not be all merely of commandment, but that we might do much also of our own mind. Since it was in His power, had He not been so minded, to extend the commandments further and to say, "he who fasts not continually, let him be chastised; he who keeps not his virginity, let him be punished; he that doth not strip himself of all that he hath, let him suffer the severest penalty." But he did not so, giving thee occasion, if thou wilt, to be forward in doing more. Wherefore both when He was discoursing about virginity, He said, "He that is able to receive, let him receive it:" and in the case of the rich man, some things He commanded, but some He left to the determination of his mind. For He said not, "Sell what thou hast," but, "If thou wilt be perfect, sell."

[Augustine of Hippo](#) wrote:

But I am aware of some that murmur: What, say they, if all men should abstain from all sexual intercourse, whence will the human race exist? Would that all would this, only in "charity out of a pure heart, and good conscience, and faith unfeigned;" much more speedily would the City of God be filled, and the end of the world hastened.^[25]

[Gregory of Nyssa](#) warns that no one should be lured by the argument that procreation is a mechanism that creates children and states that those who refrain from procreation by preserving their virginity "bring about a cancellation of death by preventing it from advancing further because of them, and, by setting themselves up as a kind of boundary stone between life and death, they keep death from going forward".^[26] [Søren Kierkegaard](#) believed that man enters this world by means of a crime, that their existence is a crime, and procreation is the fall^[27] which is the culmination of human [egoism](#).^[28] According to him, [Christianity](#) exists to block the path of procreation; it is "a salvation but at the same time it is a stopping" that "aims at stopping the whole continuation which leads to the permanence of this world."^{[29][30]}

The [Marcionites](#), led by the theologian [Marcion of Sinope](#),^[31] believed that the visible world is an evil creation of a crude, cruel, jealous, and angry [demiurge](#), [Yahweh](#). According to this teaching, people should oppose him, abandon his world, not create people, and trust in the good God of mercy, foreign and distant.^{[32][33]: 144–145 [34]: 54–56}

The [Encratites](#) observed that birth leads to [death](#). In order to conquer death, people should desist from procreation: "not produce fresh fodder for death".^{[35][36][37]}

The [Manichaeans](#),^{[38][33]: 228, 231 [34]: 56–57} the [Bogomils](#),^{[39][40][41]: 13} and the [Cathars](#)^{[42][41]: 89–90 [34]: 57–}

⁶⁰ believed that procreation sentences the soul to imprisonment in evil matter. They saw procreation as an instrument of an [evil god](#), demiurge, or of [Satan](#) that imprisons the divine element in the matter and thus causes the divine element to suffer.

[Shakers](#) believe that sex is the root of all sin.^{[43][44][45]} Thus although not strictly antinatalist, they see procreation is a sign of the fallen state of humanity.

Taoism

Robbert Zandbergen^[46] compares modern antinatalism to [Taoism](#), stating that they both "view the development of [consciousness](#) as an aberration in an otherwise fluid and fluent universe marked by some sense of non-human harmony, stability and tranquility." According to Zandbergen, antinatalism and Taoism view human consciousness as something that cannot be fixed, for example, by returning to a more harmonious way of life, but rather it has to be undone. Humans are tasked with a project of a peaceful, non-violent dismantling of consciousness. From the Taoist perspective, consciousness is purpose-driven, which goes against the spontaneous and unconscious flow of the Tao. Hence, humans have an imperative to return to the Tao. Humans have to do it spontaneously, and it cannot be brought about from "the outside" (the Tao, the Heaven, or anything else). Zandbergen quotes John S. Major et al. 2010^[47] to make the parallel between Taoism and antinatalism even clearer:

冰之凝, 不若其釋也, 又況不為冰乎 Ice is better once it melts; how much better if it had never been frozen.

Water is a traditional representation of the Tao, as it flows without shape. Ice represents the arrest of the natural flow of the Tao in rigid human consciousness. Taoist sages return to the flow like ice melting to water. But it would have been better if human consciousness never had appeared.

Theodicy and anthropodicy

[Julio Cabrera](#) considers the issue of being a creator in relation to [theodicy](#) and argues that just as it is impossible to defend the idea of a good [God](#) as creator, it is also impossible to defend the idea of a good man as a creator. In parenthood, the human parent imitates the divine parent in the sense that education could be understood as a form of pursuit of "salvation," the "right path" for a child. However, a human being could decide that it is better not to suffer at all than to suffer and be offered the later possibility of salvation from suffering. In Cabrera's opinion, evil is associated not with the [lack of being](#), but with the suffering and dying of those that are alive. So, on the contrary, evil is only and obviously associated with [being](#).^[48]

Karim Akerma, due to the moral problem of man as creator, introduces anthropodicy, a twin concept for theodicy. He is of the opinion that the less faith in the Almighty Creator—God there is, the more urgent the question of anthropodicy becomes. Akerma thinks that for those who want to lead ethical lives, the causation of suffering requires a justification. Man can no longer shed responsibility for the suffering that occurs by appealing to an imaginary entity that sets moral principles. For Akerma, antinatalism is a consequence of the collapse of theodicy endeavors and the failure of attempts to establish an anthropodicy. According to him, there is no metaphysics nor moral theory that can justify the production of new people, and therefore, anthropodicy is indefensible as well as theodicy.^[34]

Jason Marsh finds no good arguments for what he calls "evil asymmetry"; that the amount and kinds of suffering provide strong arguments that our world is not an act of creation made by a good God, but the same suffering does not affect the morality of the act of procreation.^[49]

Peter Wessel Zapffe

[Peter Wessel Zapffe](#) viewed humans as a biological [paradox](#).^[50] According to him, [consciousness](#) has become over-evolved in humans, thereby making us incapable of functioning normally like other

animals: cognition gives us more than we can carry. Our frailness and insignificance in the cosmos are visible to us. We want to live, and yet because of how we have evolved, we are the only species whose members are conscious that they are destined to die. We are able to analyze the past and the future, both our situation and that of others, as well as to imagine the suffering of billions of people (as well as of other living beings) and feel [compassion](#) for their suffering. We yearn for justice and meaning in a world that lacks both. This ensures that the lives of conscious individuals are tragic. We have desires: spiritual needs that reality is unable to satisfy, and our species still exists only because we limit our awareness of what that reality actually entails. Human existence amounts to a tangled network of defense mechanisms, which can be observed both individually and socially in our everyday behavior patterns. According to Zapffe, humanity should cease this self-deception, and the natural consequence would be [its extinction](#) by abstaining from procreation. ^{[51][52]}

Negative ethics

[Julio Cabrera](#) proposes a concept of "negative ethics" in opposition to "affirmative" ethics, meaning ethics that affirm [being](#). He describes procreation as an act of manipulation and harm — a unilateral and non-consensual sending of a human being into a painful, dangerous, and morally impeding situation.

Cabrera regards procreation as an [ontological](#) issue of total manipulation: one's very being is manufactured and used; in contrast to intra-worldly cases where someone is placed in a harmful situation. In the case of procreation, no chance of defense against that act is even available. According to Cabrera: manipulation in procreation is visible primarily in the unilateral and non-consensual nature of the act, which makes procreation per se inevitably asymmetrical; be it a product of forethought, or a product of neglect. It is always connected with the interests (or disinterests) of other humans, not the created human. In addition, Cabrera points out that in his view the manipulation of procreation is not limited to the act of creation itself, but it is continued in the process of raising the child, during which parents gain great power over the child's life, who is shaped according to their preferences and for their satisfaction. He emphasizes that although it is not possible to avoid manipulation in procreation, it is perfectly possible to avoid procreation itself and that then no moral rule is violated.

Cabrera believes that the situation in which one is placed through procreation, human life is structurally negative in that its constitutive features are inherently adverse. The most prominent of them are, according to Cabrera, the following:

- a. The being acquired by a human at birth is decreasing (or "decaying"), in the sense of a being that begins to end since its very emergence, following a single and irreversible direction of deterioration and decline, of which complete consummation can occur at any moment between some minutes and around one hundred years.
- b. From the moment they come into being, humans are affected by three kinds of frictions: physical pain (in the form of illnesses, accidents, and natural catastrophes to which they are always exposed); discouragement (in the form of "lacking the will", or the "mood" or the "spirit", to continue to act, from mild *taedium vitae* to serious forms of depression), and finally, exposure to the aggressions of other humans (from gossip and slander to various forms of discrimination, persecution, and injustice); aggressions that we too can inflict on others (who are also submitted, like us, to the three kinds of friction).
- c. To defend themselves against (a) and (b), human beings are equipped with mechanisms of creation of positive values (ethical, [aesthetic](#), [religious](#), [entertaining](#), [recreational](#), as well as

values contained in human realizations of all kinds), which humans must keep constantly active. All positive values that appear within human life are reactive and palliative; they do not arise from the structure of life itself, but are introduced by the permanent and anxious struggle against the decaying life and its three kinds of friction, with such struggle however doomed to be defeated, at any moment, by any of the mentioned frictions or by the progressive decline of one's being.

Cabrera calls the set of these characteristics A–C the "terminality of being". He is of the opinion that a huge number of humans around the world cannot withstand this steep struggle against the terminal structure of their being, which leads to destructive consequences for them and others: [suicides](#), major or minor [mental illnesses](#), or [aggressive behavior](#). He accepts that life may be – thanks to human's own merits and efforts – bearable and even very pleasant (though not for all, due to the phenomenon of moral impediment), but also considers it problematic to bring someone into existence so that they may attempt to make their life pleasant by struggling against the difficult and oppressive situation we place them in by procreating. It seems more reasonable, according to Cabrera, simply not to put them in that situation, since the results of their struggle are always uncertain.

Cabrera believes that in ethics, including affirmative ethics, there is one overarching concept which he calls the "Minimal Ethical Articulation", "MEA" (previously translated into English as "Fundamental Ethical Articulation" and "FEA"): the consideration of other people's interests, not manipulating them and not harming them. Procreation for him is an obvious violation of MEA – someone is manipulated and placed in a harmful situation as a result of that action. In his view, values included in the MEA are widely accepted by affirmative ethics, they are even their basics, and if approached radically, they should lead to the refusal of procreation.

For Cabrera, the worst thing in human life and by extension in procreation is what he calls "moral impediment": the structural impossibility of acting in the world without harming or manipulating someone at some given moment. This impediment does not occur because of an intrinsic "evil" of human nature, but because of the structural situation in which the human being has always been. In this situation, we are cornered by various kinds of structural discomforts while having to conduct our lives in a limited amount of time and in limited spaces of action, such that different interests often conflict with each other. We do not have to have bad intentions to treat others with disregard; we are compelled to do so in order to survive, pursue our projects, and escape from suffering. Cabrera also draws attention to the fact that life is associated with the constant risk of one experiencing strong physical pain, which is common in human life, for example as a result of a serious illness, and maintains that the mere existence of such possibility impedes us morally, as well as that because of it, we can at any time lose, as a result of its occurrence, the possibility of a dignified, moral functioning even to a minimal extent.^{[48][53][54][55]}

Kantian imperative

Julio Cabrera,^[56] [David Benatar](#)^{[6]: 129–131} and Karim Akerma^[57] all argue that procreation is contrary to [Immanuel Kant](#)'s practical imperative (according to Kant, a man should never be used as merely a means to an end, but always be treated as an end in himself). They argue that a person can be created for the sake of their parents or other people, but that it is impossible to create someone for their own good; and that, therefore, following Kant's recommendation, we should not create new people. Heiko Puls argues that Kant's considerations regarding parental duties and human procreation, in general, imply arguments for an ethically justified antinatalism. Kant, however, according to Puls, rejects this position in his [teleology](#) for [meta-ethical](#) reasons.^[58]

Impossibility of consent

[Seana Shiffrin](#), Gerald Harrison, Julia Tanner, and Asheel Singh argue that procreation is morally problematic because of the impossibility of obtaining consent from the human who will be brought into existence.

Gerald Harrison and Julia Tanner argue that when we want to significantly affect someone by our action and it is not possible to get their consent, then the default should be to not take such action. The exception is, according to them, actions by which we want to prevent greater harm of a person (for example, pushing someone out of the way of a falling piano). However, in their opinion, such actions certainly do not include procreation, because before taking this action a person does not exist. ^{[59][60][61][62]}

Asheel Singh emphasizes that one does not have to think that coming into existence is always an overall harm in order to recognize antinatalism as a correct view. In his opinion, it is enough to think that there is no moral right to inflict serious, preventable harms upon others without their consent. He extends argumentation by [Seana Shiffrin](#), who views procreation as always problematic due to significant harm imposed on children but she denies the inference to the antinatalist conclusion. Singh supports the antinatalist position based on Shiffrin's principle that we can only non-consensually impose significant harm on another person, if it is done for a great benefit to him. ^{[63][64]}

Chip Smith and Max Freiheit argue that procreation is contrary to [non-aggression principle](#) of [right-wing libertarians](#), according to which nonconsensual actions should not be taken toward other people. ^{[65][66]}

Cosmic mistake

Robbert Zandbergen claims that life emerges as the result of some cosmic mistake and humans should rectify this situation. One avenue of this rectification is the limiting or conclusion of reproduction. ^[9]